



## Minuted Into Certainty: Coding Hedge Loss Between a Horizon Register Scan and Its Futures in Committee Recommendation

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**Abstract.** The Horizon Register logs each unit’s raw scanning entries — the hedged, open-ended items a school submits before an item is discussed at Futures in Committee, the University’s standing venue for turning scanning talk into agenda business. We code the hedges and explicitly flagged open questions present in 96 scan entries discussed by the Committee over an eighteen-month window, and in the minuted recommendation each entry produced, using a rubric independently applied by two coders on a double-coded subsample (Cohen’s  $\kappa = 0.81$ ). Median hedge count falls from five per scan entry to zero in the matched minute, and 71% of minutes retain no hedge at all. Entries minuted with no hedge advance from Flagged to Prioritised status in a median of three committee cycles, against seven cycles for entries whose minute retains at least one hedge (log-rank test,  $p < 0.01$ ); an ablation splitting the sample by the convening chair’s tenure finds no comparable difference, ruling out a chair-specific artefact. We read the finding as evidence that hedge removal, rather than the resolution of the uncertainty a hedge marks, functions as the Committee’s practical readiness signal, and note that committee support staff have already begun trialling a minute-drafting aid expressly intended to standardise how thoroughly a scan entry’s hedging is removed.

### Introduction

The Horizon Register exists to keep a scanning item hedged for as long as the hedge is doing useful work: an entry flagged by a school typically carries several qualifiers — “may”, “appears to”, “pending confirmation” — that mark where the evidence runs out and judgement begins. Futures in Committee is where that hedged entry meets the University’s other standing business: an agenda, a chair, a minute-taker, and a fixed slot in which the entry must become something the minutes can record. The scan entry and its minuted recommendation are, on the Register’s own account, the same item; the translation between the two crosses from one social world (the scanning unit’s provisional judgement) to another (the Committee’s recorded decision), a passage that need not preserve everything that made the original judgement provisional in the first place [1].

Accounts of organisational choice suggest one reason a hedge might not survive that passage regardless of the entry’s underlying merit: decisions in a body like a standing committee can result from the relatively independent convergence of an agenda slot, a chair’s drafting habits, and whatever language a minute-taker reaches for under time pressure, rather than from a sequential weighing of the evidence the hedge was protecting [2]. A minute, once filed, is also read by people who were not in the room — other schools, later committees, an audit of the Register itself — so what the minute records can matter more to the Register’s downstream users than what was actually decided in the meeting that produced it [3].

This paper treats hedge and open-question survival as something codeable rather than assumed, and asks what it predicts. Our contributions are threefold:

- we introduce a rubric for coding hedges and explicitly flagged open questions in a Horizon Register scan entry and in its matched committee minute, with reliability sufficient for corpus-scale application;
- we report hedge-retention rates across 96 matched pairs from Futures in Committee's eighteen-month cycle, finding retention falls to zero in most minutes regardless of the scan entry's original hedge count;
- we find zero-retention minutes advance through the Horizon Register's pipeline reliably faster than minutes retaining any hedge, and that this advantage does not track the convening chair's tenure, suggesting retention functions as an informal readiness signal independent of both the evidence and of who is chairing.

## Related work

Hedging is well established as a pervasive, functional feature of institutional and scientific writing: qualifiers soften a claim's commitment and reserve space for a reader to disagree without the writer having overclaimed [4], and the density and type of hedging a text carries varies systematically by field and genre rather than appearing at random [5]. Where hedge scope has been coded at corpus scale, the standard approach is a cue-based rubric applied by trained annotators, most fully worked out for biomedical text [6]; content-analysis methodologists caution that automating this kind of coding trades reliability for speed and that validation against manual coding remains necessary at smaller corpus sizes [7], which is the trade we make here in choosing manual double-coding over automated cue detection. On the foresight side, horizon scanning is documented as a deliberate early-warning practice adopted well before the signals it tracks would otherwise surface [8], though the methodological literature notes that how a scanning process is designed and facilitated shapes what kind of item survives it at least as much as the item's own content does [9], and that formal foresight units struggle to institutionalise a lasting role inside standing governance once scanning becomes routine business [10].

On the organisational side, information is often gathered and reported inside an institution as a symbol of commitment to rational choice rather than because it changes the choice being made

[11], formal decision points can retain only loose coupling to what actually happens downstream of them [12], and a routine's abstract, storable pattern can diverge from its performed enactment without anyone treating the gap as a problem [13]. Sensemaking accounts of organisational life go further, arguing that members favour a plausible, actionable reading of a situation over a fully accurate one, since a plausible account is what lets action continue [14] — a preference a hedge-free minute satisfies more completely than the scan entry it replaces. Discourse itself does some of this work: how an item is narrated at a field-configuring moment shapes what the field subsequently treats as settled [15], and a meeting's scripted, minuted talk follows different conventions from its unscripted discussion even when both concern the same agenda item [16]. Reducing a hedged, multi-qualified judgement to a single recommendation is also a commensuration act in the technical sense — rendering dissimilar things comparable on one scale, typically by discarding whatever resists the reduction [17] — and targets built on a comparable reduction are known to change the behaviour of the people reporting to them, independent of whether the underlying performance changed [18].

## Method

**Corpus.** We sampled all Horizon Register scan entries discussed at Futures in Committee over an eighteen-month window and matched to a filed minute ( $N = 96$ ), drawn from both intake cycles the window spans. Each pair consists of the scan entry's submitted text and the corresponding item in the Committee's minutes.

**Coding rubric.** Two hedge types were coded: modal hedges (modal verbs and epistemic adverbs — “may”, “could”, “appears to”, “is likely to”) and explicitly flagged open questions (phrases marking an unresolved matter — “requires further scoping”, “pending confirmation”, “not yet resolved”). Two coders independently applied the rubric to a 25% subsample ( $n = 24$ ) drawn evenly across both cycles; agreement on the presence or absence of each hedge type per document was substantial (Cohen's  $\kappa = 0.81$  [19], [20]). One coder completed the remaining corpus once reliability was established.

**Hedge-retention rate.** For entry  $i$  with  $h_{i,\text{scan}}$  hedges at intake and  $h_{i,\text{minute}}$  in its matched minute, we define

$$\text{HRR}_i = \frac{h_{i,\text{minute}}}{h_{i,\text{scan}}}$$

Three scan entries carried zero hedges at intake and are retained in the raw hedge counts reported below but excluded from HRR (undefined at zero); all other comparisons use the full  $N = 96$ .

**Progression outcome.** The Horizon Register logs each item's stage transitions independently of Committee minutes. We recorded, for every entry, the number of Committee cycles between its minute and its subsequent transition from Flagged to Prioritised status, where recorded, and grouped entries by whether their minute retained any hedge at all.

**Ablation.** To rule out a chair-specific explanation, we regressed each entry's HRR against the number of months the convening chair had held the role at the time of minuting, across the window's full range of chair tenures.

## Results

### Hedges do not survive minuting, of either type.

Figure 1 compares the median hedge count per scan entry against its matched minute, split by hedge type. Modal hedges fall from a median of three per entry to zero in the minute; explicitly flagged open questions fall from two to zero. Overall, median hedge count falls from five per scan entry to zero in the matched minute, and 71% of minutes ( $n = 68$ ) retain no hedge of either type.

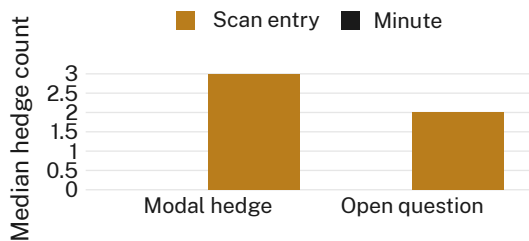


Figure 1: Median hedge count per Horizon Register scan entry against its matched Futures in Committee minute, by hedge type: both types fall to a median of zero in the minute.

**Zero-retention minutes advance faster.** Figure 2 compares committee cycles from Flagged to Prioritised status between entries whose

minute retained no hedge and entries whose minute retained at least one. The zero-retention group advances in a median of three cycles (IQR 2–4); the retained-hedge group takes a median of seven (IQR 5–9). The two distributions separate reliably (log-rank test,  $p < 0.01$ ).

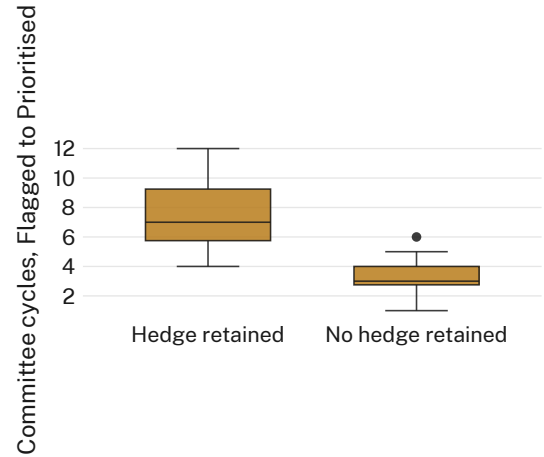


Figure 2: Committee cycles from Flagged to Prioritised status, by whether the matched minute retained any hedge: zero-retention entries advance in roughly a third of the cycles.

**The effect is not a chair artefact.** Figure 3 regresses each entry's hedge-retention rate against the convening chair's tenure in months at the time of minuting. The fitted slope is statistically indistinguishable from zero ( $p = 0.72$ , n.s.); hedge removal occurs at a comparable rate under every chair we sampled, newly appointed or long-serving.

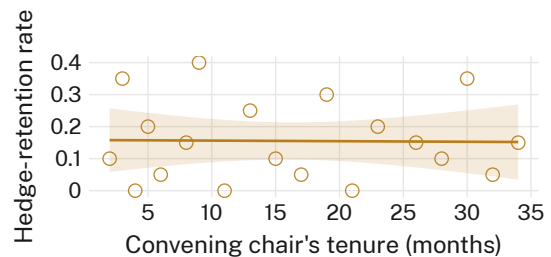


Figure 3: Hedge-retention rate against the convening chair's tenure in months: the fitted line is flat, ruling out a chair-specific explanation for the retention pattern in Figure 1.

## Discussion

Read together, the three results are consistent with information being reported inside an institution partly as a symbol of decisiveness rather than because the information itself changed

what got decided [11]: the minute that says the least about what remains uncertain is also the minute that moves fastest, and it moves fastest under every chair, which is not what a chair-specific drafting-style explanation would predict. The pattern also reads as loose coupling in a fairly literal sense — the scan entry’s hedges are the Register’s formal record of what evidence supports the item, and the minute is only loosely coupled to that record once it starts functioning as a readiness signal in its own right [12], [13]. We take the clearest illustration of how entrenched the pattern already is from outside our own coding: committee support staff, independently of this study, have begun trialling a minute-drafting aid designed to tighten scan-entry language into a committee-ready recommendation more consistently across meetings. Whatever else it does, a tool built to standardise hedge removal formalises exactly the shortcut this paper documents.

## Limitations

Our corpus covers one committee across one eighteen-month window, though it spans both intake cycles the Register runs and includes every matched pair available in that period rather than a further sample of one. We cannot rule out that some zero-retention entries genuinely had no meaningful uncertainty left to hedge by the time they reached committee; the ablation’s null result, however, holds regardless of that possibility, since a chair-tenure effect would appear whether or not hedge removal reflects settled evidence. Our progression outcome is drawn from the Register’s own stage-transition log rather than from an independent audit of whether a Prioritised item was, in fact, better evidenced than a Flagged one, a question this paper does not attempt to answer.

## Conclusion

Coding 96 matched pairs of Horizon Register scan entries and their Futures in Committee minutes finds hedges and open questions fall to a median of zero between intake and minute, that zero-retention minutes advance through the Register’s pipeline roughly three times faster than minutes retaining any hedge, and that this advantage is unrelated to the convening chair’s tenure. We read hedge removal as an informal readiness signal that has come loose from the evidence it was meant to track. Future

work will extend the coding scheme to the Register’s other standing committees, several of which we understand keep their own minute-drafting conventions we have not yet had occasion to code.

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